



rosy picture. To begin with, although you could write and use your own Nexus, or trust a non-Microsoft party to service you one, chances are that like the Web browser, most users will stick to the micro-kernel that ships with a Palladium PC—a Microsoft one. If Microsoft emerges as the sole or the most used identity server, the system could place the company as the gatekeeper of identification and authentication, a powerful role to say the least. Finally, if the Nexus and TAs served by Microsoft take a monopolistic market share, the company could ask application developers for royalties while granting them use of its enabling software.

Palladium is also a good Digital Rights Management (DRM) solution. Content can be granted or denied to a computer based on its identity and the level of trust tagged to it. Consider content renting, where a content provider can release a movie to your PC in return for a contract (implemented by TAs) that dictates your application to collect Rs 50 from you every time you view the movie. This is understandable till the content provider insists that you download its trusted software at a price to watch the movie, also at

a price. The way that software and hardware work together under Palladium could ensure that while running the movie, screen capture hardware and software can be disabled as part of the contract, dictated by the content provider and enforced by the TAs and the Nexus. While this may slow down piracy, it could also mean that your TV tuner and video combination card has been disabled, rendering one section of your system useless.

A TA, in combination with a Nexus can also define expiry dates for data. E-mail can be automatically and permanently deleted after a period of 30 days, doing more harm than good. While national security might demand such a system, market manipulation, shady accounting or other anti-trust policies of companies might very well go unaccounted for. Finally, a security policy defined by a TA can ascertain that only a particular pair of application and data goes hand-in-hand. While such a system can provide enhanced security to a user—your e-mails, for example, can only be read by a proprietary application developed in-house, thus minimising corporate espionage and information leaks—it can also be used as a mar-

ket-grabbing tactic. If a leading office refuses to read files created by other applications, what can you do?

Think about it

Thanks to product activation, Microsoft has already prevented Office XP and Windows XP from working if parts of a computer are changed or if you divulge some personal information. A central security repository has been implemented in the form of the MS Passport's Wallet system—if your Wallet account is cracked, all the sensitive information is visible to any malevolent user. The port system has already shown some weaknesses. Security patches for Microsoft server, OS and even its mail clients are a regularly feature in our download queue.

The cornerstone of the Palladium system is trust. It is a philosophy that is reflected across its architecture via trusted spaces, trusted agents and spheres of influence. The question to ask is then, 'Can we have a single monopoly to manipulate our personal data and communication under the pretext of security? Is this really secure and at what cost?' 

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